

PCB-01 · BODY OF KNOWLEDGE — EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Project Controls Body of Knowledge — executive summary

What the thirteen domains cover, and what a credential built on them does and does not assert

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The Project Controls Institute's Body of Knowledge is a thirteen-domain, sixty-one-knowledge-area statement of what a project controls professional must know, weighted forty per cent project accounting and finance, forty per cent project management principles and twenty per cent AI. This summary explains what the framework claims, how the examination samples from it, what the PCL-AI credential therefore asserts about a holder, and the four things it deliberately does not assert.

— About this document

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Contents

1. What the Body of Knowledge is	4
2. The claim underneath it: one discipline, not three	4
3. The architecture in one view	5
4. What sampling from it means for the examination	5
5. What the PCL-AI credential asserts — and its four limits	5
6. What the Body of Knowledge deliberately excludes	6
7. Where the framework is unfinished	6
8. How this goes wrong	7
Related	7
Sources and standards	7
Status and version	8

The Project Controls Body of Knowledge — executive summary

In one paragraph. The Project Controls Institute's Body of Knowledge is a thirteen-domain, sixty-one-knowledge-area statement of what a project controls professional must know, weighted forty per cent project accounting and finance, forty per cent project management principles and twenty per cent AI. This summary explains what the framework claims, how the examination samples from it, what the PCL-AI credential therefore asserts about a holder, and the four things it deliberately does not assert.

Who this is for. Project controls managers, cost engineers, planners and commercial managers deciding whether to certify; and the heads of function, PMO leads and hiring managers who will read the credential on someone else's application.

— 1. What the Body of Knowledge is

The Body of Knowledge is the published statement of what the Institute holds a project controls professional must know, structured so that it can be studied, examined and argued with. It is thirteen domains, subdivided into sixty-one knowledge areas, each of those divided into numbered topics on the pattern `Domain.KA.Topic` — so `6.3.1` is an address, not a page number. The numbering is the working part. An examination item, a revision plan, a competency assessment and a complaint that something was tested unfairly can all name the same location and mean the same thing.

It is not a textbook of one organisation's method, nor a rival to the frameworks already in use. Where a body of practice exists — the PMBOK Guide, AACE's Total Cost Management framework, ISO 31000, the Scrum Guide, the IFRS standards — the Body of Knowledge names it, explains its principle in the Institute's own words, and says where a practitioner must exercise judgement instead. It reproduces none of them. What it adds is not another method but an **integration**: the claim that the finance, delivery and AI material belong in one competent head rather than three adjacent ones.

The full framework runs to roughly a million characters of manuscript and is not republished in this series. What follows is the argument, not the content.

— 2. The claim underneath it: one discipline, not three

Most certification frameworks in this space certify a slice. A planning credential certifies logic and float; a cost credential certifies estimating and earned value; an accounting qualification certifies recognition and reporting. Each is defensible, and each leaves a seam. The number that reaches the board has crossed all three: physical progress becomes earned value, earned value becomes a forecast, the forecast becomes the percentage complete that determines recognised revenue, and the revenue becomes the profit the market sees.

The Institute's position is that the seam is the discipline. Someone who can compute a cost performance index but cannot say what their revised estimate at completion does to reported revenue is not half-competent; they are competent at a task and not at the job. [PCB-03 – Why 40/40/20 defends that claim in full.](#)

— 3. The architecture in one view

Three groups carry the framework: **project accounting and finance** (Domains 1–4) at forty per cent, **project management principles** (Domains 5–12) at forty per cent, and **AI knowledge and practical approach** (Domain 13) at twenty per cent. Weights attach to groups, never to individual domains, and no per-domain percentage is published. The domain-by-domain map is [PCB-02 – The thirteen domains at a glance.](#)

Two features are easy to miss. AI is not confined to Domain 13: every non-AI domain carries embedded coverage of how AI assists that subject and where it must not be trusted, and the twenty per cent is measured across that whole surface. And the domains are sequenced so later ones re-use earlier machinery rather than restating it — agile is authored after earned value because it re-uses the same arithmetic on variable scope, and the AI domain last so its workflows can cross-reference the domains they operate on.

— 4. What sampling from it means for the examination

The examination is built backwards from the framework, not assembled from good questions. Every form meets the same specification: all thirteen domains sampled at the published group weights, in four-option multiple-choice items with a single best answer, tagged recall, application or analysis and deliberately weighted towards the latter two. The sitting runs ninety minutes. No formula sheet is provided — selecting the right formula is part of what is assessed. Scoring is criterion-referenced, not graded on a curve.

Two numbers a reader will look for are absent, deliberately. **There is no published item count:** item counts will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis with practitioners, and until that runs the honest answer is that the number does not exist. **The pass mark is not finally set:** the platform is configured at sixty-five per cent, and the definitive standard will be set by a modified-An-goff standard-setting study — a documented judgement about what a minimally competent professional must demonstrate rather than a round number chosen for pass-rate optics. Both are stated here rather than smoothed over, because a candidate who discovers them later will reasonably feel misled. [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) has the full treatment.

— 5. What the PCL-AI credential asserts — and its four limits

A PCL-AI holder has demonstrated, at a single sitting, competence against a published framework at a published standard. The substance of that assertion — the propositions a holder is claiming to be able to act on — is set out in [PCB-04 – What a project controls professional must know.](#)

Four limits belong in the same breath.

It is a point-in-time assessment, not a warranty of practice. Valid for three years and maintained through continuing professional development including a mandatory AI-currency component. It says what was demonstrated, not what is being done today.

It is not accreditation. The framework is developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles. PCI is **not accredited** by ANAB, IAS or any other ISO/IEC 17024 accreditation body, holds no governmental approval and claims no university equivalence. The Institute is at step one of a published four-step path — standard defined, then candidate enrolment, then accreditation, then recognition — and says so.

It certifies knowledge and judgement, not outcomes. Nothing here predicts a salary, a promotion or a project result, and PCI makes no representation about any of them.

It is separate from membership. PCI membership grades — Student, Associate, Professional, Fellow — are a different ladder. A credential is earned by examination; a grade is a standing. Conflating them is the most common error in describing PCI, and it is worth an employer's attention on a CV.

— 6. What the Body of Knowledge deliberately excludes

A framework is defined as much by its boundary as its contents, and three exclusions are load-bearing.

No jurisdiction's law or tax treatment is presented as universal. Where accounting, legal or tax treatment varies by country, the framework teaches the principle and says that it varies. No candidate is assessed on one country's rule.

No vendor's tool is examined. Scheduling, cost and analytics software change faster than a certification cycle. The framework examines the method — a forward and backward pass computed by hand, a forecast method selected against the cause of a variance — because that survives the tool.

No blueprint exists yet for the sibling credentials. The Institute certifies three credentials at Leader level: PCL-AI in project controls, PFL-AI in project finance and PML-AI in project management. This Body of Knowledge and its blueprint are **PCL-AI only**; no blueprint, weighting or item specification exists yet for the other two, and any document implying otherwise is wrong.

— 7. Where the framework is unfinished

Every domain is a first authored draft pending subject-matter-expert review, and the appendices are assembled from finished domains. The job-task analysis that will validate the sampling has not run. The first edition's effective date is [\[CONFIRM: first-edition effective date for the PCL-AI Body of Knowledge\]](#). [PCB-05 – How the Body of Knowledge was built](#) sets out the standard the material has already passed and the gates ahead of it.

Publishing the unfinished parts is a choice with a cost. A framework that will govern other people's careers should be arguable before it is binding, and a reader who can see which parts are settled is better placed to challenge the parts that are not. If a domain misses something the job requires, the Institute would rather hear it now than defend it later.

— 8. How this goes wrong

The most damaging misreading treats a domain title as a subject boundary. Domain 6 is not "the earned value questions": earned value logic appears inside contract, schedule, risk and agile scenarios, because that is where it appears at work, and examination scenarios cross domains deliberately. The second — reading the group weights as a study-time rule — is treated in [PCB-03 – Why 40/40/20 §8](#), along with the other three ways a weighting is misread.

— Related

- [PCB-02 – The thirteen domains at a glance](#) — the printable map of all thirteen domains and sixty-one knowledge areas
- [PCB-03 – Why 40/40/20 – the weighting and what it claims](#) — the argument this summary asserts and does not defend
- [PCB-04 – What a project controls professional must know](#) — the propositions the credential asserts about a holder
- [PCB-05 – How the Body of Knowledge was built](#) — the authoring, review and evidence standard behind the material
- [PCB-06 – Using the Body of Knowledge: a guide for employers](#) — role design, hiring and development built on the framework
- [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) — how the framework becomes an examination form

— Sources and standards

- PCL-AI Body of Knowledge, first authored draft, thirteen domains and sixty-one knowledge areas ([docs/bok/](#)), August 2026. Authored under the credential's retired code; the credential is now PCL-AI.
- The Style Spine — Conventions of This Reference ([docs/bok/00-style-spine.md](#)), August 2026: the authoring standard, domain map and 40/40/20 weighting.
- Examination Blueprint ([docs/downloads/examination-blueprint.md](#)), August 2026: group weights, item format, cognitive levels, formula policy, standard-setting commitments.
- PCI Canonical Facts ([docs/publication-framework/00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#)), verified August 2026: credential codes, examination configuration, accreditation wording, membership grades.

Standards named in this document — the PMBOK Guide, AACE's Total Cost Management framework, ISO 31000, ISO/IEC 17024, the Scrum Guide and the IFRS standards — are named as frameworks the Body of Knowledge references and explains in its own words. No edition, clause or wording is cited here, because no edition was verified for this summary; the Body of Knowledge itself names them at the point of use.

— Status and version

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